

FREE PROMPT PACK

Stop Starting From Scratch

10 AI Prompts for Grants, Donors, and Boards

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Free to use and share. If you pass it along, tell them where it came from.

A Note From Joe

Here's something I see every week. Two people at the same organization open the same AI tool. One gets a first draft she can actually use. The other gets mush and decides AI is overhyped.

> *Same tool. Different prompt.*

A prompt is a job description. Hand a new hire a sticky note that says "write the grant" and you'll get exactly what you'd expect. Give them the funder, the program, the deadline, and what good looks like, and now you're working with somebody.

These ten prompts are the job descriptions. Copy them, fill in the brackets, and let AI handle the first draft. Your team gets their hours back for the part only they can do.

Joe Paul
Founder and CEO, OptimaNova AI

How to Use This Pack

- **Fill in every bracket.** The more you give it, the better it gets. Messy notes are fine.
- **Paste the real stuff.** The RFP, last year's report, your meeting notes. AI works from what you hand it.
- **Answer its questions.** Several of these prompts tell AI to ask you questions before it writes. Answer them. That's where the good stuff comes from.
- **Keep private things private.** Donor names, client details, salaries, and health information stay out of free AI tools. If your organization has an approved tool, use that one. If you don't have an AI policy yet, that's a conversation worth having this month.
- **You're the editor.** AI writes the first draft. You write the last one.

These work in ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, or Copilot.

Grants

1. Write a Need Statement Funders Feel

Use it when you know the problem cold and it still comes out flat on paper.

> You are an experienced grant writer who has sat on foundation review panels. Help me write the statement of need for a proposal to [funder name].
>
> Our organization: [who we are, who we serve, and where]
> The problem we address: [describe it in your own words; messy is fine]
> Data we have: [local statistics, waitlist numbers, last year's results]
> One real example, details changed for privacy: [a short story]
> What this funder cares about most: [paste their priorities or mission statement]
> Length limit: [word or character count]
>
> Before you write, ask me up to five questions about anything missing or unclear. Then write the need statement in plain language. Lead with the people affected, use our data as proof, and connect the problem directly to this funder's priorities. Flag any claim that needs a source.

Joe's tip: Paste the funder's own words into the "cares about most" line. Reviewers notice when your proposal speaks their language.

2. Score Your Draft Before the Panel Does

Use it when your proposal is written and there's still time to fix it.

> Act as a tough, fair grant reviewer for [funder name]. Below are the funder's guidelines and scoring criteria, followed by my draft.
>
> Guidelines and scoring criteria: [paste]
> My draft: [paste]
>
> Score my draft against each criterion from 1 to 5. For every score below 5, tell me exactly what's missing and suggest specific language to fix it. Then list every requirement in the guidelines my draft doesn't address at all. Be blunt. The panel will be.

Joe's tip: Run this in a fresh chat. A new conversation reads your draft with fresh eyes.

3. Turn a Program That Works Into Outcomes You Can Prove

Use it when the funder wants measurable outcomes and all you have is a program you know works.

> You are a program evaluation expert who explains things plainly. Here's our program: [what we do, who participates, how often, for how long, and what changes for people].
>
> We have [number] staff and no evaluation budget. Build a simple logic model with inputs, activities, outputs, short-term outcomes, and long-term outcomes. For each outcome, suggest one realistic way to measure it with the staff we have and no new software. Flag any outcome we'd struggle to prove. Format it as a table I can drop into a proposal.

Joe's tip: Always tell it your staff size. A measurement plan that ignores capacity looks great until the grant report is due.

Donors

4. Write a Thank-You That Names What the Gift Did

Use it when a gift deserves more than a form letter.

> Help me write a thank-you to a donor. Keep it warm, specific, and under 150 words.
>
> The gift: [amount or type, and what it supported]
> What it made possible: [one concrete result, number, or moment]
> Our relationship: [first-time donor, longtime supporter, board connection]
> Signed by: [your name and role]
> Our voice: [two or three words, like warm, plain, a little funny]
>
> Skip generic lines like "your generosity makes a difference." Name the specific thing this gift did. Give me two versions: a short email and a handwritten card.

Joe's tip: Leave the donor's name out of the prompt and add it yourself at the end. One specific detail about what the gift did turns a receipt into a relationship.

5. Bring Back a Donor Who Went Quiet

Use it when someone who used to give hasn't in a while.

> Write a short email to a donor who gave [amount and how often] and hasn't given since [month and year].
>
> What's happened since: [new results, a milestone, one story they'd care about]
> What I'm asking for: [a gift, a visit, an event, or just a reply]
>
> Don't guilt them and don't mention how long it's been. Open with what their past support built, share one update, and end with one easy next step. Keep it under 175 words. Give me three subject lines to test.

Joe's tip: The easiest first ask is a reply. Once they're talking to you again, the next gift gets a lot easier.

6. Turn One Story Into a Full Appeal

Use it when you have a moment that captures your work and an appeal to write.

> Here's a story from our work, with names and identifying details removed: [the story].
>
> Turn it into a year-end appeal letter of about 400 words. Open with the person's moment. Use our results to show this story happens again and again: [your numbers]. Make one clear ask: [amount or action]. The person in the story is the hero, and our organization is the guide who helped. Write at an eighth-grade reading level. Then give me a 75-word version for email and a two-sentence version for social media.

Joe's tip: Get permission from the person whose story it is, even with the details changed. Trust is the whole business.

Boards

7. Turn a Pile of Reports Into a One-Page Board Brief

Use it when the board packet is due and the information lives in six different places.

> You are a chief of staff preparing a one-page brief for our board. Here are this quarter's materials: [paste program updates, financial summary, key numbers, staff notes].
>
> Write a one-page brief with four parts: three wins, three risks to watch, the decisions we need from the board, and the five numbers that matter most, each with a one-line explanation. Plain language, short bullets, no jargon. Then flag anything in the materials that contradicts something else.

Joe's tip: That last line earns its keep. AI is quick at spotting the number in the finance report that doesn't match the number in the program update. Better you find it than your treasurer.

8. Rehearse the Hard Questions

Use it when you're walking into a board meeting with something that needs a yes.

> I'm presenting [the topic, like the budget, a new program, or a strategy change] to our board. Here's my summary: [paste].
>
> Play three board members: a skeptical finance chair, a longtime member who guards the mission, and a newer member who asks the basic questions everyone else is thinking. Have each ask the two toughest questions they'd likely ask. Then help me draft a short, honest answer to each. Point out anything in my materials that will raise eyebrows.

Joe's tip: Say your answers out loud before the meeting. Reading an answer and saying one are two different skills.

Running the Shop

9. Turn Meeting Notes Into Decisions and Owners

Use it when the meeting ended and nobody's sure who's doing what.

> Here are my notes from today's meeting: [paste notes or a transcript].
>
> Pull out every decision we made, every action item with an owner and a deadline, and every open question nobody answered. If an action item is missing an owner or a deadline, flag it. Format it as a short follow-up email I can send to everyone who attended.

Joe's tip: The flags are the whole point. Most meetings end with "someone should," and then nobody does.

10. Find Out Where AI Already Lives in Your Organization

Use it when you suspect your team is using AI and nobody's keeping track.

> Help me write a short, anonymous survey for my staff about how they use AI at work today. I want to learn which tools they use, for which tasks, how much time it saves them, what worries them, and what they wish they could do.
>
> We have [number] staff across [departments or roles]. Keep it to 10 questions or fewer, in plain language, mostly multiple choice with two open-ended questions. Make it clear nobody is in trouble for using AI, or for not using it. Then suggest how I should share the results back with the team.

Joe's tip: Most leaders guess low. In the organizations we work with, people are almost always already using AI. They're just doing it on their own, with no plan and no guardrails.

Your Next Step

> *Ten good prompts will save you hours. A plan saves your team a year.*

If your people are already using AI and you can't tell whether it's working, that's the gap we close. Start with our free assessment at survey.optimanova.ai. It's twelve questions, about six minutes, and you see your results the moment you finish.

Then let's talk.

OptimaNova AI helps nonprofits, foundations, associations, and purpose-led organizations put AI to work: strategy, training, custom tools, and the guardrails to run them well. We've trained more than 2,000 people and worked with more than 25 organizations.

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